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Michael Max Fleming

Bassist Michael Max Fleming gained experience with a doo-wop vocal group and R&B bands before moving to New York in 1963. He has performed with Rahsaan Roland Kirk, the Bill Lee Bass Choir, and Mary Lou Williams, and was an integral part of the Jazzmobile project.

Michael was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on June 8, 2017 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have bassist Michael Max Fleming with me today in preparation for a gig at Hamilton College. I'm going to start out with a real easy question: What is your idea of the role of a bass player in a band?

MF: Well in a sense the B-A-S-S is the B-A-S-E of the harmony. Is that good enough?

MR: That's good. Who's the main timekeeper in the band? Because I've had drummers say, "Well it's me of course." And then I've had bass players say, "It's really me."

MF: Well you say main, well let me try. What it turns out to be, the predominant utterance of the rhythm section. In other words, it's not either or. I mean some people play like that but to me that's an inferior approach. I don't think that way. I got the time, you got the time, although there have been times when I've had to dominate or people have tried to dominate me. But to me it's about a consensus. And to me those that are successful rhythm sections are those that have the same thing in mind in working together and can feel each other. Not, "I got it, you follow me," or "you got it." To me that is totally beneath me in anybody I ever want to play with.

MR: Do you have particular rhythm sections that you over the years have told your students to listen carefully to?

MF: No.

MR: Really?

MF: No. I just haven't. Maybe I should have but I never did it.

MR: All right.

MF: That's not part of my approach. That's not part of my method.

MR: Well where did your method come from? Now was there a point in your life where you said, "I think that I could be a professional musician."

MF: Okay, now —

MR: I mean, because some people really know by the time they're in fourth or fifth grade what they want to do, and often times it's musicians. But some people, it's later in life that they sort of fall into it. So I'm basically wondering, when did you take the path?

MF: Okay. My first instrument was piano and I just realized that in my community, as six year olds we had a band. All right. Later I went to accordion. When I went to accordion I had fantasies and visions of playing in front of people. And I just had visions of myself doing that. After that, after I stopped playing the accordion I was a doo-wopper, from the age of nine I could give everybody their parts. "Bobby you do [scats]" and "Johnny you do this." At nine I could do that because my mother taught me as a six-year-old at the piano she would rehearse an imaginary choir. "Sopranos, altos." So at a very young age I was exposed to that. But that went on and on and on. And my uncle, my mother's youngest brother, was a virtuoso of many instruments. And he told me, he said, "Michael if we get you a bass I'll take you on the gig with me." Like that. I wanted to make money and have fun. So I went to the — I was in the seventh grade, eighth grade, tried to take up the upright bass. "Well sorry, right now we have enough bass players but if you would like I'll teach you, you can play the tuba." So at age 13 I started playing the tuba. Basically self-taught because the high school teacher, he was busy writing music for the spring show. So he said, "Here, you take this" — I can't do it now. He gave me the mouthpiece, gave me the horn, showed me the first page. "If you have any questions just come back to my office and ask me." So guess how many times I had to go back to him.

MR: How many?

MF: Never.

MR: You had an ear for low notes.

MF: Well I knew the bass clef from the piano and I had the instruction in the book. I played. So I played all through high school. I represented my school in the All-City Band Orchestra. But in the meanwhile now, okay, so there's a lot. That was one high school, by the way it was the same high school that Frank Foster went to, and there's another guy Fred, a piano player. I can't think of his name. They both went to that same high school. But anyway so in the tenth grade the teacher tells me — you wonder when did I decide, I just tell you, the teacher, who was a bass player, said, "I need somebody for the spring concert." So he showed me how to hold the bow. He gave me two lessons and said the same thing, sent me in the room where the instruments are kept. "If you have any questions come ask me." But before that there was another school I went to where this teacher must have sent a note — he said, you know when you transfer from one school they said good student, does this, you know. I mean on that level I would think that teachers — because that teacher, and when I went to that teacher he locked me in a room too and gave me some tuba solos. "Hall of the Mountain King," "The Marines Hymn" [scats]. At the end of the year I played it at the concert. Anyway that was that. Then I went to this next teacher who gave me the upright bass. And he let me take it home over the summer. And my uncle would come by every day. He didn't have a piano, my mother

let him play. He showed me how to play tunes, how to spell changes. So then the bug — it bit me.

MR: That's really interesting. And when you say he showed you how to play tunes, can you describe that a little more?

MF: Okay. The first tune I learned on the bass, and I teach my students this tune now, to this day, and later on I had the privilege of meeting the man who wrote the song. The song is "Lover Man." Now the first two changes to "Lover Man" are D minor to G seven. Those are open strings on the bass. So that's the first song my uncle taught me. And he wrote down changes around that time. You seem like you have a question.

MR: Did he — I'm getting pretty specific here, but do you remember —

MF: That'll be fifty dollars.

MR: Yeah. This is going to be an expensive one because I've got a lot of these kinds of questions. Did he write D minor?

MF: Yes. Chord symbols.

MR: Right.

MF: D minor seventh. With slashes, one, two.

MR: And how long did it take you to learn what does that mean, the little m and the 7.

MF: Well all I played was roots at first.

MR: At first, of course.

MF: And you know so I didn't try to walk. I would play one, two three, four; one two, three four, da-da-da G, G, C, da-da-da G, G, C, down F, F, F.

MR: Yeah.

MF: How long does that take?

MR: Well for some people it would take a while if they didn't have ears.

MF: Yeah. Well now you're bringing up a good subject, about ears. Yeah. So does that answer that?

MR: Yeah.

MF: That was a fifty dollar question. Because that's powerful stuff.

MR: Well maybe we can go higher than that.

MF: Never mind. Never mind. This is not about that. This is about information being recorded. And getting an idea of how different people take a pathway to the same thing.

MR: Yeah. But it's so important for the bass player — horn players can get by a lot without knowing exactly what these chord symbols mean. Because they don't have to play all the time and if they make a slight error in a note they can slide up and make it sound like they meant to do it.

MF: Where I come from it's more specific than that.

MR: Okay. Well I'm fascinated by bass players and what they do.

MF: But during that time, because I was being taught how to play the chords, at the time what they call two-five. I didn't know it was that. I didn't know. I didn't hear that until maybe I was college age. Two-five. That was just — I knew that that was a natural progression.

MR: Yeah. So when your uncle was teaching you this in the beginning, what year was this? What years? About when? Come on. You can tell me.

MF: 2016. I was crawling. Milk was running out of the side of my mouth.

MR: Because I want to know what would the music, the popular music at the time.

MF: It was the 50s.

MR: Okay. So you were hearing some doo-wop.

MF: Okay. See now you're getting into some juicy stuff.

MR: Yeah.

MF: My mother played piano. Her father played piano. But my father played, and my aunts played, we call it the Victrola, the record player. So I had — my father made sure I heard every kind of music that ever existed.

MR: Okay.

MF: So in other words, three years before that my aunt gave me, my aunt who was a sister to this brother, gave me a "Charlie Parker with Strings" 78 for my birthday. And all of my mother's sisters were married to amateur musicians. One was a drummer, one was a piano player. So each time when I'd go to everybody's house, and I was an only child, music was my babysitter. So at one place I'd hear Erroll Garner, you know. At another place I'd hear Sarah Vaughan. Each house, another house I'd hear Max Roach. So I was inundated with music between my father, who probably felt somehow I might one day be a musician although he didn't want me to be. But he was very fatherly and he wasn't going to destroy me. But I think he wanted me to be something else but he couldn't deny that it was in me. And going back to your question, my senior year of high school I spent all that time saying, "Do you want to be a musician? If you want to be a musician are you aware, are you willing to pay the price to do all it takes to become a musician?" Going through stories of hardships that musicians went through and this and that. So halfway through, "YES!" I'm going to be a musician. And I say this now half-heartedly. But to me at that time that was — what do priests and nuns take? — a vow of poverty? So I was looking at it like that.

MR: That's a pretty mature attitude to even sort of be aware that it's an important decision and that you're going to have to pay some serious dues to do it. Maybe because you had musicians around you and your uncle and you were a little more aware of the realities of it?

MF: I was playing with him at 17, that summer. That's before this time when I'm making this decision. I'm at home on a Sunday afternoon and the phone rings. It's my uncle calling

my mother Bec, her name was Rebecca. "Bec, the bass player didn't show up, can you sent Michael over?" to what was Newport, Kentucky, which was the Las Vegas, Sin City of the world. Everything went on over there. And you know what my mother said to him? "Are you out of your mind? Send my baby over there with those cut-throats?" Silence on the phone. But she had to back off. Because the year before that I turned professional doo-wopper and she said I couldn't go. And she found my clothes in the hallway and she found out that I was going anyway so she gave me what little money she had and sent me on my way. So she saw this is who my son is. If I tell him no he's going to go anyway. So finally she says okay and put me in a taxi and sent me over there. And I began to play with Eddie "Cleanhead" Vincent.

MR: Oh no kidding? Wow. So you were playing a mix of jazz and blues?

MF: He was a consummate jazz player. He wrote "Tune Up."

MR: Oh right.

MF: He wrote "Four" — Miles Davis stole them. But I knew that then see so I'm not just coming in this music like — I'm not going to mention any music schools but it's a little more like destiny like. Like you need to know, to get this stuff. And this is what's good about this interview because not everybody took the path that I took. So go ahead.

MR: Do you recall what you made on that gig?

MF: Oh man you ask some nasty questions.

MR: No. I bet it's great.

MF: Do you want to know what color underwear I have on? Tough questions. Okay I'll tell you. Oh man, if I had known [inaudible] agree to do this interview here. Wow you're good. Okay.

MR: I made four dollars on my first gig.

MF: But you're shameless. You don't ask, you don't care what I think of you. But anyway here we go. I'm going to answer you.

MR: Okay.

MF: At the time all the other musicians in Cincinnati, black musicians, because black musicians did one thing and the white musicians — we're talking about the 50s. We're not talking about, well there's some strange stuff going on now but we're not talking about that. They made ten dollars a night. Across the river you made fifteen.

MR: Was that because of the white community on one side of the river and the black community on the other?

MF: No, no, no. With the river it had to do with the nature of — they had casinos. They had money and they were smart people. Smart people. I'm not a businessman — oh I get myself in so much — but smart people know that sometimes if you pay people better they'll, they'll appreciate the job better and not think about going somewhere else. Or

there's a lot of reasons why you pay people that short-sighted people don't understand it. But there's people, "Well but I'm losing money." Yeah but you've got to look at the big picture. Smart people pay people and they get better results. That's just what I know. I'm not a businessman. I'm not an economics professor. I'm just a plain old jazz musician that's been all over the world. That's all.

MR: That's good. Okay so did people tell you, "You've got to move on. You've got to go to New York" did you hear that?

MF: That's so good. There's two ways I heard it. Every musician, some of who worked in Las Vegas, some of whom worked with what they call carnivals traveling around. They always said, see we have a saying about — Cincinnati is a good place to be from. Which is true. So a lot of the musicians when they came through and they saw it was a young guy, would say, "Don't get stuck here. Get out of here. Don't get stuck." Like that. And then there was a school teacher who was frustrated and he was a jazz musician and he couldn't get a job in the Cincinnati school system but he was a substitute at our school. And just like I asked Coleman Hawkins, I always sought counsel. You know. I said, "Do you have a formula, what should I do. I want to go to New York and be a jazz musician. What do you think I should do?" He was trombone player which is not an easy instrument to make a living off of in the jazz world. So he says, "Well number one, go to school or whatever, go and learn to get around your instrument." Very simple. That's the terminology. Learn to get around your instrument. "Number two, go on the road, play with rhythm & blues bands, play with whoever you want to play with. Get experience. Then you move to New York and find your way." So that's what I did.

MR: What were some of the — did you play with rhythm and blues bands and swing bands?

MF: Yeah but they were right there. They were right there. Well I was doing it with "Cleanhead" and then Scott. What was his name. The organ player that played.

MR: Shirley Scott?

MF: No, no, this is a saxophone player. He was a genius. And I'm having trouble remembering names but yea, the answer is I played with, I can't think of their names but there were a lot of local rhythm & blues bands that I played with. The main thing what he was saying is get experience playing. So I did that. And yeah, so I did that, and then I went on. You were asking me if I played with the bands and I'm saying yeah, even though I can't — so I'm just trying to think, but they don't come to mind. Okay but go on to the next —

MR: Okay, so did you save up some money before you went to New York? See I never did that.

MF: And I'm not going to tell you how much now.

MR: Okay I won't ask you.

MF: Talking about the past, you know more than my mother knew about it, man. Come on, man. Okay.

MR: Okay. So you moved to New York and —

MF: Yeah I had a little nest egg.

MR: Nest egg, yeah.

MF: I had to, that was, you know.

MR: How does a young man find his way in New York City?

MF: Okay how did I get there. Okay. I went to New York in the fall of 1963. Spring of '63 I came to New York with a local band which was called Curtis Peagler and the Jazz Disciples. Then they recorded.

MR: He was a sax player, wasn't he?

MF: See you're good, yeah. That's when I went with him. We played at Count Basie's club because Count Basie was managing them at the time. He later went on to play with Count Basie's band and Ray Charles and different people like that. So I came with that band in the spring. And I made a contact with different people. Made contacts you know. And then that fall a childhood friend of mine who was a trumpet player, his name was Jerry Ayers, he came to his grandmother's funeral and so he was in town for three or four days. And he said, "If you come to New York you can stay at my place. I've got a room for you." So within a few hours, I broke my mother's heart I'm sure, I had to get out of there. That was it. And I took whatever my life's savings was, whatever that was, and said I'm going to make it, do or die. Another background to that, 1963, a few years before that, I was in this club with a guy named DeFelice. He was a drummer. The trumpet player was a guy who played with Duke Ellington, his name was Bill Berry. And there's another guy who wrote for Woody Herman, his name was Gordon Briscoe. He went to that first high school where I played a tuba. And across the street a woman owned a club called Mother's, named after the TV show "Mothers," it was a rainbow club, started bringing in groups from New York. So every group that came in I met them and hung out with the bass players. So then when I got to New York I had contacts. And I met a lot of people, I'm not going to name their names, but I met them. So when I got to New York it wasn't like who are you, you know. They knew me.

MR: So then you started getting calls, maybe to sub for people? "Hey I can't make my gig tonight, can you cover for me?" Is that how that works?

MF: Yeah. I was telling you downstairs about the organization. And so this puts it in — this is going to make history now, but it was a group called Professionals Unlimited. And basically they didn't think that we — basically it was an organized clique. But what makes it remarkable out of all kinds of cliques was that these were all bass players from different cities. See at the time there was a Chicago clique, there was a Detroit clique,

you know, there was a Los Angeles clique there was a Bos — so what I mean by that is usually those groups exchanged work among themselves. But what happened when all of these bass players came together with a common purpose, in other words to dramatize the bass violin — "Wow, we've got a little stew here." The guy from Detroit, we're at a meeting, "Hey I've got this" — but what my forte was, was that where I came from they didn't really have a clique. So I wasn't a threat to anyone. I just had to play good. And that's what I tried to do every time I put out. I played with all my heart and soul. That's what happened.

MR: What happens as a bassist when you go to play a gig and maybe it's a pick-up group or something, and someone calls a tune and you don't know it. But you're supposed to know it. You're supposed to be responsible for outlining the changes. How do you get through that?

MF: I got through that from one big experience from — I didn't tell you but the first major gig that I got in after I moved to New York was with Mary Lou Williams — the liaison between the swing and the bebop. A lot of people don't know it but she helped Monk form his sound, helped Bud Powell form their sounds. She was well respected. She's my musical mother, and that's within the first six weeks I got into her hands and her influence. So she's coming out of retirement, she's playing at Wells. Upstairs they had two bands. A lot of places had two bands. I'm upstairs and I come up off of a break one night and there's this guy sitting there, an older gentleman. His name was Ben Webster. So I come up to him, "Good evening, sir." All prim and proper. And in a way you'd say a country bumpkin, I don't know, with a Midwestern accent. So I sounded like somebody from Chicago maybe. So, "What would you like to play?" talking to Ben Webster. "Body and Soul." Now from my Cincinnati training there was a culture to that. If you couldn't call the changes to the tune all the way through you don't play that. "I'm sorry, could you play something else?" I'm telling you the culture with my uncle and the way they worked. So now I say that and a chill comes over the room. Because people sitting in are not really playing but they're watching but I don't know if it was because the expression changed on his face or whatever but I says, "I don't know that but could you call another tune please?" But I get this response, didn't come rapidly enough — oh I can't say this —

MR: You can say it.

MF: It's a word, it's a dirty word.

MR: It's all right.

MF: So you know what he said to me? "You ain't shit." Now my uncle was also a street person and those are fighting words partner. So now thinking of my uncle, I'm saying, "Hmmm. I've got a rough customer here." So according to my uncle, if you're going to jump on somebody like that you orchestrate it, first you're going to do just like a football.

That's where he learned it from. First you snap the ball, then you make an end run, and then you fake. So which way am I going to whip this old man? So the voice came in my mind says, "Don't do that, Michael because you know Charles Mingus' got a bad reputation and you just got in town. Don't you start a fight, you'll never get work." So whatever happened? I don't remember what tune we played but we played something else and then I walked across the floor to Mary Lou Williams, who was sitting there. And she's looking at me with this indefinable look. And I'm like a little kid coming to my mommy. And she looks at me and she says, "You ain't shit. Man don't you ever embarrass me like that. When you don't know a tune use your ears." You asked me about how I do what I do. Use your ears. That was 1963. On and off I played with her up until 1971 and even further than that. And during that time she gave me little hints of what you do. So when I come on the gig and somebody, "Do you know 'S'wonderful'?" Yeah. If they ask me, "You know 'S'wonderful'?" Yeah. Play it.

MR: Okay.

MF: First time around — second time around got you. But she showed me. So does that answer you?

MR: It does. And it's a perfect story because "Body and Soul" —

MF: It's a sophisticated tune.

MR: It is. And if you don't know it, how do you know where that bridge is going to go, right?

MF: Two years later I would have got to it. And with that whole thing it's an unwritten rule that you know, if you hear something one time down you should be able to get enough of it and manage enough of it to be able to, second time around, do something with it.

MR: Okay.

MF: I mean that's with the people I know. I don't know with somebody else. But I'm telling you that's the level that I've operated at.

MR: Okay. I think it's really interesting that Mary Lou Williams said —

MF: Oh see well don't — see that's why I started, I said don't concentrate on that, that's the story.

MR: I know. But I like the way that she didn't want to be, you embarrassed her.

MF: She meant that though.

MR: Yeah.

MF: Because what it is, see they go back, they go back to Kansas City. And so they had mutual respect. And so they've got a circle of, and I wasn't in that circle, you know, but he's coming to see her, I don't know, maybe he flew in from Chicago or whatever. And you've got this little creep with you? The great Mary Lou and you can't do better than this little greenhorn? It was like that.

MR: Oh boy. That's great. Good story. Is there a difference in playing behind singers than playing behind —

MF: Absolutely. Absolutely. Like I said, my first wife was a singer. So I came in contact with all that that entails. And so I got to see, naturally I knew how musician, a lot of musicians hate singers, oh my goodness, "Oh here comes one," say ohhh. But because I was married to singers and I liked singers, and my father and my aunt they played singers, I enjoyed singers. I didn't have a problem with them. That's how I learned, listened to the Ink Spots. That's how I learned bass lines as a little kid. All the standards that Bill Kenny used to sing. So what's wrong with singers. My father remembered — my father hated bebop by the way. "That's skeet-skeet music. They don't play the melody. Play the melody, son."

MR: What? Ski?

MF: Skeet skeet. Play the melody. "Remember that son." Because he would ask people advising musicians, told them it's important to learn the melody. So I didn't have a problem with singers. And my wife would come home crying about all the dirty tricks that musicians would play on her. And so what happened with me, I played with anybody. That's a whole 'nother story. Before I got to New York I quit for a year and then I didn't play for a whole year. Because I didn't want to play rhythm & blues. I was an elitist. I only played jazz. If I couldn't get a jazz-playing gig, if I couldn't get a gig playing jazz no don't call me, I don't want that. I'm a jazz musician. But then so I went and got a day gig for a whole year. And I was miserable. So at the end of that year I started saying you know what? If I can get a job playing anything I'd do it. It'll get me out of this damn gig. So when I came to New York that was all part of my mindset. I'll play with anybody. That's the other part of playing in any key, all of that. So there's a number of factors that helped me to be able to play music. I've never done, since I've been in New York I've never had a job doing anything else.

MR: Never had a day gig since you moved here?

MF: Not non-musical. I mean there was a time I tried to find out about business but I wouldn't make my living off of that. That was just experimenting.

MR: Well a good musician doesn't have to like the music they play on every gig.

MF: You mean they just are very professional.

MR: They just need to be professional, right?

MF: But there again you've got to talk to each person. That's philosophical. It depends where they're coming from and then what their sentiments are and how they define themselves. You know? You have just as many musicians as you have varieties of flowers. Because we're people and we're different. And it's okay.

MR: Did you have a sense at that time, in the mid-60s, you're making your way, the idea of "making it" of getting to a certain goal thinking that's when I'll really be happy. That's what I want to get to. Was it defined or was it just a gradual —

MF: No. Because I don't separate music from life and life from music of you from me or me from this floor. It's all life. And trying to define life which is nearly impossible. You come up with little tidbits or little ideas of what life is. And there's a word that comes in: perfection. Perfectionist. So when you go down that road you realize things are to be perfected. Perfection is to be pursued. But once you get to perfection that changes nothing. Everything changes. So you go "now I'm the king of the mountain." No in answer to your question, no I never did that.

MR: Okay. It reminds me of something I think you said.

MF: Ohhh. What's that?

MR: This was from I think a *New York* Magazine or something like that.

MF: A quote?

MR: A quote.

MF: How did you find that? That's interesting. Go ahead.

MR: It says, "I push myself to find a way to do things different in a world where nothing is new under the sun."

MF: Well see that's kind of in line. Yeah. I don't remember saying that.

MR: Yeah. That sounds good.

MF: Yeah I'll take it. But it's that kind of thinking. You know because music doesn't have to be all stiff and prim and proper. There's formalities for everything and sometimes you need to be formal and times when you need to be informal and earthy. So I guess it depends on the situation in terms of seriousness, that I might apply to a situation. But yeah. So what's the point of me saying that? How did that strike you? Or what did that —

MR: Well I was curious about what you meant about nothing new under the sun, if you were talking specifically about music or even new things come from somewhere else, so it's just an evolution.

MF: Yes. Change is a matter of adapting, taking a wheel and using it for something else. A steering wheel, whoa. A Ferris wheel? It's a wheel. It's not a koopa-koopa. You know. I'm going to put it on a merry-go-round, it's still a wheel. That's what I'm saying.

MR: Okay. You mentioned back in Cincinnati you had a pay scale for black musicians and a pay scale for white musicians.

MF: Yeah but that was just between Kentucky and — but generally speaking, yes. The white musicians made more. Even their scale, we had two different unions.

MR: Did the same thing happen in New York?

MF: Yeah well that's not music that's just culturally the way things have evolved. You know. Queen Elizabeth, her son's children, from where they had to go from where I had to go, it's different because of the cultural — and it just happens to be — now if you go over to Egypt and your skin's white, you might be a second-class citizen because you're not the right religion. So it just happens that we're talking about white and black. But it's very clear how that is the way it is. George Washington, was he Chinese? Edison? Was he Jamaican? Was he from the Congo? Edison? Even though there were people there who were working under him who had very bright people, very black, bright black people that helped him invent some of the things that he got credit for. But because of the way things were set up socially, anthropologically, that's the way it is. I mean it's obvious and I don't grieve over it because it won't make a difference, to grieve over it. But it's obvious that's the way it is. You know? And that's the way it is. And that has been our history. It doesn't mean there it is, and it's not stagnant, it's changed. There has been progress. We had a black president. How about that. We had Jackie Robinson. How about that. So it's changing. But if you just open your eyes, I mean we don't have to have a debate, a formal debate over — that's the way it is, man.

MR: Do you think it will always be that way? No, well, I apologize, because you already answered that question. You're talking about a progression. And just because something is the way it is now, it may change. But —

MF: Unfortunately, how about this, which is a big part of the hysteria. What if it evolves to the roles are reversed? And it may be, sure. But I'm not saying that's the way it's going to be. But I'm just saying that's the nature of how things evolve and change. It's that volatile. One event can mess everything up, man, or change everything. One event. One dumb, stupid move. Yeah. I'm not saying it's dumb for it to be reversed. I just want people to get along. So I'm not interested in — that's all. Do I want to be king? Yeah, sign me up.

MR: Can you describe for me what let's say the late 60s, if you were doing a record date with Rahsaan or anybody else, what exactly, how much time you got in the studio and what was the pressure like. Was there pressure?

MF: Okay. Okay I did two records with Rahsaan. The one "I Talk with the Spirits," you may have run across that where it's "Serenade to a Cuckoo" — that's me. Okay? For me — and that was my second record. My first record I made with him they didn't put my name on the record jacket. So that was traumatic.

MR: What was the name of the record?

MF: "Gifts and Messages."

MR: Okay.

MF: That was on Mercury, right after Mercury turned into Limelight. So, and on the track he announces my name so that's better than — because a jacket can get torn, so it's almost indelible. Not really indelible but it's right on the record as opposed to being on the liner notes. But what are you asking, what was it like?

MR: Were you more critical of your own playing because you knew you were going to hear it back? Did you play differently?

MF: With him it was one thing, with him the records I made basically we played what we played on the gig. We didn't write charts. I made up my parts. Nobody gave me a part. The whole group we just — it was a beautiful thing in a way. And so when we went into the studio I was nervous on that first record. But we were playing what we played every night. Everything he did was so spontaneous. You never knew what he was going to do. He never counted off the tunes. He never gave keys. He just started playing.

MR: I just got this image of you and the piano player like, you know, one of you whispering to the other what key we're in or something?

MF: No. Never. That's part of it. Remember what Mary Lou told me, "Don't you embarrass me." And so I learned to use my ear, you know, and that was it. On gigs I would go with guys that would play me, "Put the pinkie here." I wouldn't give in to that. Even though they were offering that. They'd play a new tune and sometimes I'd act like it but I wouldn't do that. You know why I wouldn't do that? This is — I didn't get this from Mary Lou Williams I just understood that it wasn't a good thing to do. Because if you get used to watching — because my uncle, in the beginning he would do that sometimes. He would call a tune out, when I went over there with Cleanhead he called out "D minor, G seven, C seven, four beats." He could do that. He was good. But what I found is if you got accustomed to that there was going to come a time when you'd be in the crook of the piano and you couldn't see their fingers. Ut um. No. So I can't do that because that's going to weaken me. I'm going to develop a dependency. No, no, no, no, no. I don't do that. Does that make sense to you?

MR: It does indeed. And you know what's replaced that now is the Internet.

MF: Oh, the Internet.

MR: If you want to learn a song it used to be you'd put the record on and you'd play, you'd listen for those bass note. And now you can type it up and there it is for you. And you can start to depend on it.

MF: Yeah well that's the problem, because I've had people that I've taught and then I've run into them years later. They go on the gig with a little fake book sitting right there. That just turns me off. Maybe it's okay. But back in the day which as far as I'm concerned from 1945 to 1965, that was when jazz was at its peak. And most of those groups then, if they weren't big bands, parts of them, Cannonball Adderley, Miles Davis, you never saw

them with music on the bandstand. Think about it. They would be dressed up, and they didn't do it. So that's what happened to me. So I came up in that period. And that was all in line with having the ears and everything. And I ran into a shop when I got to the place where I was going to play on Broadway. Because for ten years I hadn't read any music, although I had gone to a conservatory and studied sight reading and all that stuff. I had formal ear training before I got with Mary Lou, in school. Do-re-me/re-me-fa. Do-re-me/re-me-fa/me-fa-so. I knew all that before I got with her. She didn't teach me all of that. You know what I'm saying? So yeah, so what I really was trying to do was get into the studios. It was like starting from scratch. Because here I'm doing the other thing, of, "Use your ears," to like, "play this, play that." Twelve-eight to four-four. [scats] One-two-three-four-five-six-seven-eight. All kinds of stuff. All kind of crazy rhythms, which we specialized in with Rahsaan. But it wasn't written out.

MR: Yow.

MF: Music is wonderful, and it's limitless. And to me this interview is good because my path is a little different. Everybody's path is different. Everybody, especially jazz musicians you know. And that was the thing even back in Cincinnati, before I came to New York, do your own thing. That's what you're trying — I'm still trying to do it. I still don't know, what's my own thing? I'm still, because that's constantly changing you know. What I did last year might not work this year.

MR: The twenty years you picked —

MF: '45 to '65.

MR: '45 to '65, I was really in love with the mid-60s and Cannonball Adderley in particular. I loved the combination of his bebop influence but then what we called "soul jazz" I guess, and him in particular. Did you ever play with him?

MF: No, no. Never ever. "Cleanhead" would always refer to him. "I know that little fat boy." And he talked about John Coltrane. "That little boy played in my band." You know. So "Cleanhead" was in, and I was playing with "Cleanhead" when he went to New York and he made a record with Cannonball. I was playing with him as a kid, then. That had to be the late 50s. So yeah. But Cannonball, there was a fad, and that was the period, there's two particular styles that made the music flourish: the bossa nova and the soul to funk that Cannonball played. "Dat Dere", "Dis —", you know all of that stuff. And yeah, the world was like, what was his name the General, Patton said oh he was so fortunate to be Patton. General Patton, he was so fortunate to be alive while the world was aflame with war. So with me, I was so lucky in 1959 and the early 60s that the world was aflame with jazz, because we played, we would go on the road for four, six weeks at a time and the New York bands had two bands. We would alternate with Sonny Rollins, alternate with

different people They'd play an hour, we'd play an hour. This was going, there'd be six sets.

MR: Was this with Rahsaan?

MF: Yeah. the Five Spot — not the Five Spot — yeah maybe it was, there on the corner of Third Avenue and St. Mark's Place. We'd play. We'd come in, and we'd play the first set. We'd play then Sonny Rollins, he'd come in and burn. We'd come back and we're gonna burn. It would go on, six nights a week. And you would be booked four weeks, six nights a week. Two major bands. On my break I might go over to the Vanguard. "Miles is over at the Vanguard." To jump in a cab and go over, it was like that.

MR: What a time.

MF: It was wonderful. And I could feel it, I remember when it began to wane you know.

MR: When?

MF: Like I said, '66, '67, '68 it started to — you noticed they didn't have two bands anymore. But that was a carryover from World War II. In World War II people were working night shifts, working around, and they'd have bands — okay the bands — we worked from 10:30 to 4. Bands don't play at four in the morning anymore. That's 'cause during the war that's the way it was with people's jobs and things like that. And that's where the two bands came from, that format. But me myself and people that I've talked to, now people have jazz at 7:00. That makes sense. We had to make an adjustment. It makes sense. People get home from work. If you live on Long Island, if you live in the city, they don't want to wait around until 10:00 to come and go home. Come and have dinner, have jazz, then take your drive home. So there has to be adjustments. The one I'm talking about is informal. There was no formal declaration. I'm just telling you as a working musician how I could see what happened.

MR: I saw it when I was playing when the drinking age went up. That affected a lot of the club work also. Were there a period of lean years. I mean you were sort of just talking about that it started to change. Did that became like lean for you? Harder to make a living?

MF: No, not really. The two bands weren't existing but what happened is things opened up more because, remember before when I first got to New York it was a cabaret law. You couldn't have drums except in certain places with certain kind of licensing. So and that was just perfect for me. It threw the rabbit in the briar patch or wherever the rabbit got thrown. Because that was my format. My uncle would come by and we would play just bass and piano. So most of the jobs around town were bass and piano. And I know I didn't — there you go you're saying, did you depend on the drummer, I didn't have a drummer. I was the drummer. So that's for me, I never depend on a drummer. But one thing that I've learned, drummers even throw things at me, but I didn't fight them. With some groups that's an ongoing thing. "This is mine." Mary Lou just taught me certain

things about that too, about the drums. The drum is the most domineering instrument. Did you ever see a man riding on an elephant's back? So there's things that can be done.

MR: That's good.

MF: There's things that could — but some of my best friends are drummers because I've been standing near them all my life. Well I've got to be a dummy to not understand — you spend a lot of time with drummers I think you'd better learn how to get along with them. I think that's the way to go. Does that make — that makes sense?

MR: It does indeed. Who were your — I notice you played with Jimmy Witherspoon and Billy Eckstine, more good singers, Chet Baker.

MF: Yup.

MR: All good?

MF: Gloria Lynne, Dakota Staton, Betty Carter, Josh White.

MR: You must have passed the auditions. Josh White.

MF: The folk singer.

MR: You were mentioned with Bill Lee like was in that.

MF: That's probably where I got it. Mose Allison. Ever heard of him?

MR: Yes indeed. Seventh son.

MF: Well see but he was borderline folk. He was, in fact if it hadn't been for Mary Lou I don't know how I played with him, because he's unique. He's one of a kind. He has his own notation for his own stuff. And if you look at it and compare it to your usual way of analyzing it wasn't that, I just had to go ahead and play. Okay. Mose Allison was one of the most different people that I ever played with. And one night I was there and I guess Bill Lee would have sent me to the Top of the Gate, I was playing with him. I came down and there's Bill Lee standing there. That used to happen to me a lot. I said, I'm saying, "Why didn't he take the gig. He's sending me on the gig." And I guess he wondered what on earth is this guy going to do with Mose? I'm not talking about — Mose had his own stuff, that's what I'm saying. But that was a shock. And I had that happen to me a lot. A guy'd send me on a gig and then I'd look down and they're there. What the — and the only two reasons I can think of is they're wondering how I was going to handle this person or you know, if I was worthy of being sent on a gig you know. But that happened to me a lot on good gigs too. A guy, "You sent me on the gig, why didn't you make the gig?" I didn't say that but that's what I was like, very curious. What the heck.

MR: Well we've talked for over an hour here.

MF: Yeah.

MR: I enjoy your outlook and your positive attitude. If you hadn't become a musician did you have a second interest? Could you imagine doing anything else?

MF: My father was a politician. Election Day was a big day at my place. I sat on the knees of ambassadors. My father was in contact with senators and presidents and vice-presidents. And I think in his heart that's what he wanted me to do. But there was something about him where he couldn't force it on me. But that's what he really wanted. Like if you are a three-year-old, and he says, "Hello young man, how are you, how are you doing, what are you going to do when you grow up? What are you going to be?" "A lawyer." Just a little baby. That's the way I was groomed. Is that strange?

MR: Well I'm glad the music won out personally.

MF: Well I look at it as I was destined to. I don't understand it. For me, like I say, I wasn't bragging when I said that I never had a real day gig or like that. I'm overwhelmingly humbled by, hey, I got to do what I want to do, man. You know. Look, I can't think of anything greater. I mean it hasn't been easy. There was times when I was saying, "Which bank am I going to rob." No I'm dramatizing, but I'm saying there were times when I lived in a room a fourth the size of this room we're in now. I had to walk up four flights of steps with my bass, have to get up, after 4:30 in the morning playing a gig, move my car at 8. Oh that's been in New York City, come on man. It's not all peaches and cream you know. There's been times. One time a guy didn't like my behavior. "You know guys like you get a surprise. Maybe something like throw him through this window." Or you're walking down the street and you get run over. "You're a wise guy, huh?" I've been through all kinds of stuff. You know what I mean? All kinds of stuff. I worked with Freddie Cole, Nat Cole's brother. The best of everything. The best of everything. Anything on the menu. Lobster, steak, anything. We never came through the back door. Never. Then those other guys who are standing in the kitchen dripping, eating a sandwich. You know. And you've got to come up through the back elevator. So there's a lot to the music. But the good thing is I've been able to meet all kinds of people. All kinds of people. Just a wonderful thing. All kinds of musicians. And for me the greatest thing that's ever happened to me is that I've been able to play with the greats. Bill Evans. Kenny Barron. You know I've had a lot of people call me that I couldn't go work with. Horace Silver, Art Farmer, just hear their voices on the phone.

MR: Right.

MF: So it's been good to me.

MR: Well on that note, I appreciate you spending this hour with me. It's been very informative and interesting.

MF: Okay.

MR: Thanks a lot.

MF: All right. If you start getting rich, I want ten percent.

MR: All right. We've got a little contract just for that.

MF: Anyway it was a pleasure doing it and I hope you use it for good.

MR: Definitely.

MF: Okay.